

Paragon

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Chapter 1 New recruits

— Prisoners, form ranks !

There he stood, the Queen's killer. From what I heard in the wagon, he killed a royal knight and the queen at a banquet.

— From today onward, you populace join the anti monster battalion. For those who received the death sentence, welcome to hell. You are going to the front line in 2 hours.

I am sentenced to death. So, this is my end, huh? Tonight I will be delivered.

— As the most ancient prisoner, my work here consists of making you fight for another day.

Oh, was he? I killed a child because I was hungry. I don't deserve to live.

— Rally up ! The guards will give your equipment.

The guards looked at me with disgust in their eyes - as they should.

I got a gambeson with claw marks on the neck. I guess getting fresh gear is out the question for prisoners. The bastards also gave me a one-handed mace. I never used weapons before. What do they expect me to do with that?

The area was nearly empty. Apart from the soldiers and a few veteran prisoners, there were only a couple of tents.

— So Sir Queen killer, started one prisoner who got arrested for theft, where is the rest of the battalion?

— What rest of the battalion? We are all. The others died in the last monster's assault.

In the corner of my vision, I spotted my carriage's neighbour. Poor him. Couldn't pay his taxes. Now he has got a 2-year contract here. The guards gave him a crossbow.

— You rat ! I ain't dying here for your ass, said the thief.

The thief went toward my carriage neighbour and grabbed his crossbow. He was about to shoot a guard when the Queen's killer grabbed him by the neck, then threw him to the ground.

— I don't care what your crime was, you come to the front with us starting today.

The thief's hair went up on his arms.

As the calm crawled back into the encampment, a lone rider, with arrows in his spine, came crashing down a few metres before me. I went to try to rescue him.

Did the battalion get regular soldiers too? I took off his helmet. The poor man was dead; he wouldn't need it anymore.

With the metal protection in my hand, I was horrified. This guard . . . was escorting us here half an hour ago.

As I stood there, I heard it. The cry of a child. It had the same cries as the one I killed.

My leg hardened. My heart raced. Chills ran up my spine.

From behind a tree, I could see its nails. Longer than my mace. How could it be?

I quickly equipped the dead guard's helmet. All of this only to see its eyes, peaking behind the same tree.

— Come fight me ! I shouted.

The thing jumped. It leaped ten metres onto my shoulder without a sweat before I could even give a swing. It was skinny, without muscles. However, it was unbearably heavy. My leg instantly flinched when it got on me.

My carriage neighbour shot a bolt in his head. No blood came out. The creature didn't seem to bother either. It dragged its claws across my gambeson. I couldn't do anything - I was paralyzed.

— Orc attack !

I heard arrows whistling. I gave a quick glance at my carriage neighbour only to see him with one in his heart. Unhappy that I diverted my gaze, the thing started to cry once again. Please, it said I'm hungry.

The sound it made made me feel like vomiting.

This was my moment to die. It was sooner than expected, at least I did try to fight. As I was about to close my eyes, a sword penetrated through the thing's chest.

— Be gone, Daemon !

My saviour swung the creature on an orc wielding a bow. He dragged me into the mud until I was out of reach of the monsters.

My arms and legs were shaking like crazy. I was about to die. Why does my body tried to fight that thing? I gripped my mace so hard that my hand was numb and bloody.

— Wake up ! Wake up ! I heard while going unconscious.

I finally recognized the prisoner that saved me, the Queen's killer. I tried to speak, but no sound came.

He looked at me as if he wanted to say something. His mouth opened slightly, then closed again.

Instead, he hurried back to my carriage's neighbour. I watched him kneel. The scene froze for several seconds. When he returned, the body in his arms, his grim look told me everything.

— Why did you save me? I killed a child !

I said it. Now everybody knew.

— And you feel guilty, am I right?

— Of course.

— Then, don't pay for your crime by your death. Pay by your life. Each monster that you slay is one less that could ravage our land and kill the children. If you really feel guilty, then make sure it does not happen again, by living.

— I don't want to die, I replied.

— You don't have to. You survived the hardest part.

I could hold back my tears any longer. They ran wild on my cheeks. Saving people ... through living?

— I'll try.

By the time I wiped my eyes, the Queen's killer was already running back to battle.

Chapter 2 Stealing is living

— We caught a fugitive, said a guard.

He grappled me by my belt and threw me off the horse.

— Isn't that mister clever - or should I say mister thief, said the Queen's killer. I must say that I'm impressed by your cowardice.

The prisoner took a knife and tossed it to the ground in front of my face.

— Fight me. If you manage to kill me, you're free.

There was my chance. I grabbed the weapon and launched myself on him. Not even a second after, I was back on the ground. I could taste the blood in my mouth.

I tried to crawl away. Nothing could do. The Queen's killer knelt down and punched me another time to the face.

I didn't have any energy to resist. For the whole night, I was out in the forest running away from here. I could no longer hold the knife. I couldn't even raise my arms. My eyes started to close by themselves.

— I know you still have a couple seconds before fainting, so hear me out. Your behaviour led to the death of three other prisoners yesterday. It is a miracle that you could survive more than five minutes outside this camp. Remember that when you decide to flee again.

Then everything became black. I woke up in a tent. It smelled like spices and herbs. The place reminded me of my hideout.

My group of thieves was not covered with gold, but we still had enough money to afford those luxuries. Our chief always prepared us some great meals with them.

— Oh, I miss you, Nerissa.

— Wrong person.

I jumped out of bed only to see someone with a plague mask.

— Call me Phoenix, said the plague apothecary. With all of that, you seem ready for your first mission.

— No ! My face still hurts.

— Since you excel at fleeing and stealing, you'll travel solo. Paragon entrusts you to fetch an artefact.

— I'm still injured !

— Silence you ignorant. You will act as God intends !

God ? Of course, I have to deal with a heretic now. Why do these events happen to me ?

— The artefact resides in an orc camp 5 leagues from here. Order from Paragon: if you come back empty-handed, only death awaits you.

So anything I do will see me dead. How funny.

A guard opened the tent entrance panel to escort me. Not far away, a saddled horse was waiting for me. The guard took the horse's reins and led it to the outskirts of the camp. I got a sword and a lance to defend myself. How nice of them to spend that much equipment on a coward.

Before I could leave, Phoenix came back with a strange bag.

— Take this, he said while giving me the bag. Since the orcs visited us yesterday, I feel obligated to give them a present.

I didn't know what was inside. It smelled like saltpetre.

— One last information for you. Paragon named all the surviving rookies for yesterday's convoy. Welcome in hell, Little Mouse .

The plague apothecary slapped the horse. It went at full speed and without knowing, I was already deep inside the forest.

I didn't have a map. Only the general direction was given to me.

After a moment, I was surprised that no birds were singing. At this time of the day, in my natal region, it would sound like an orchestra. I still remember the lake near my hometown being full of life.

Only the sound of branches crackling under the horse's weight brought me back to reality. I spaced out for so long I had no knowledge of where I was. The horse showed signs of nervousness.

On my far left, I heard another branch crack. This time, it wasn't my fault. I halted my course and drew my sword.

A growl came from behind me. More branches cracked. Then multiple stringed bows. They were encircling me.

An orc, mounted on a giant wolf, appeared in front of me. Nearly twenty metres away. How didn't I see it before ?

— Human, put tha metal stick away.

Two other riders came from behind. They each had a spear with a steel tip.

I stared at the weapons. Everyone knew orcs didn't know how to forge steel. At least, everyone in my old crew did. Apparently, we knew less than we thought.

My life is far more valuable than glory. Let's listen to them. Might give me some discussion leverage later.

— Follow.

They led me to their camp. Once we arrived, their leader shouted a sentence in his language. I don't know any of the orcish languages. A couple of children orc came out of their hut to celebrate.

— Strip, we loot you.

In one of the hut entrances, I saw an orc, back curved like a willow tree. In one hand, it had a cane. In the other, a carved stone partially wrapped in cloth. It was most likely a shaman, and that stone was most likely the artefact I was tasked to retrieve.

The orc chieftain grabbed my bag and threw it at the children. Without hesitation, they took the bag and called all the other younglings. I could hear them laugh in a hut until I heard a spark.

Only one of them had the time to get out. The hut disappeared in an explosion. Multiple planks flew and killed some of my captors.

It was wrong to kill children, but it was my only chance not to die. I sped up toward the shaman. My lance pierced its torso and broke there. I dropped the weapon and caught the stone flying. When I grabbed the artefact, a scream echoed in the forest.

The chieftain shouted some orders while pointing at me. My life was in immediate danger. I changed course and headed to the forest.

The horse was more than happy to quit this place, but not for long. Multiple orc riders started pursuing us.

— We are in trouble together, I said to my mount. If you keep me alive, I'll make sure you won't get hurt.

On my right, two orcs rode the same wolf. They both sat on a dual seat saddle. While the first rider focused on the path, the second one pulled the string of his bow. Even though the arrow was far from hitting me, if I have to deal with more of them, they will get my ass.

While I was focused on the archer, a wolf went to my left and jumped on me. I managed to draw my sword in the air. There ain't no way I was letting that stupid dog take my life. I stabbed it in the neck. Now, my horse was knocked to the ground and many orcs and wolves surrounded me.

— Choose, said the chieftain. Die by me. Die by apostle.

Apostle?

I didn't have much time to think about that. A war cor played not far away. The orcs started to look away toward the sound. The chieftain ordered the orcs and some of them went away.

Another note of the cor played. In the distance, I could hear the sound of weapons clashing. The chieftain continued to dispense orders.

It couldn't finish, a horse rider came from behind and stabbed it with a lance. Even with his armour, I could recognize him, the Queen's killer. Another rider, with a plague mask, followed him.

As the orc rushed to avenge their leader, the plague apothecary threw them some sort of powder. After, he muttered some incantation and the powder ignited, burning the orcs and their mounts.

— Paragon, help him.

As fast as he arrived, the apothecary departed to join the other prisoners.

The Queen's killer unmounted his horse. Not even two steps later, the chieftain rose and jumped on the armoured prisoner. Both on the ground, the chieftain grabbed the Queen's killer's knife.

It was on top of the prisoner. Blood dropped from its mouth to the prisoner's face. Paragon's muscles were shaking; however, the blade slowly lowered.

I was about to help him, but I saw her.

— Nerissa? This is a warzone. What are you doing here?

— Brother, said a silhouette. Give me the stone and flee.

— Don't listen to its lies ! shouted the Queen's killer. Kill the daemon while you still can.

— Killing apostle ? asked the chieftain. The rat not strong enough for that.

The woman advanced toward me. A split second, I saw a different image of her. I saw her beheaded. Blood all over her chest. Head rolling on the ground. Like when I abandoned her to flee; the last time I ever saw her. Then she returned to her normal appearance.

Sword in hand, I trusted in her heart. Blood started running along the blade and reached the guard of the weapon. Her mouth became redder until blood flowed out of it.

— Why didn't you flee ? Like you always do. It was an order.

I was about to release a bit of grip and pull out the sword.

— If you show any fear or resent, the daemon will kill you. End your work and push the sword deeper !

— Please, Ed, give me the stone.

My arms were paralyzed. With all the mental strength I had, I put the sword's knob on my belly and pushed with my legs. I could hear her scream of pain. I could hear her crying. I could hear her beg.

She put her hand, full of blood, on my face.

— Ed, please, I love you.

No, she didn't. This love was only one-sided. I pushed the sword all the way. The daemon screamed one last time, then faded away.

— You human rat ! Me gonna kill you for killing apostle.

This gave enough time for the Queen's killer to grab the knife and stab the orc's neck. I rushed toward him and dragged the cadaver away.

— Little Mouse, said Paragon lying on a tree's root, you did great.

Why did I fight ? Why did I even do all of this ? I could've just left with the horse when they sent me off. No one would have stopped me. Yet I didn't.

Chapter 3 Fire, the true and only God

Another batch of injured.

— Line them up by severity, I ordered.

— Yes, mister Phoenix.

Missing an arm on this soul there. Perhaps you could. . .

Pretentious Voices. To think you possess influence over this body ! A lot more you need for that plan of yours.

I unfastened one of my pouches and pinched a measure of powder between my fingers. After applying it to the open wound, I unwrapped some spiked leaves and burned them. Still burning, I shoved them onto the fresh powder. His screams became weaker. Good. The pain had finally overwhelmed him.

— This one will heal. Get him out of here.

A guard dragged the unconscious body out of the tent.

You save him because of our power. Submit at once and you could save more.

Enough ! Five years ago I killed you. Stay dead, you weak God !

We told you before, there are only two ways out. End yourself with us. Leave this body of yours to our control.

The more you speak of nonsense, the more the first option seduces me.

We look forward to it.

Before I knew, my arm moved. I hadn't told it to. My knife rose towards the prisoner's throat. I tightened my grip until my fingernails dug into my palm. For a moment, neither of us moved. The injured prisoner stared at me. His legs were shaking.

We almost had him.

— Switch.

I exited the tent as another entered to replace me. Today's battle went horribly. Seven deaths. Twenty injured, for now. We almost exhausted our prisoner pool from the last convoy three days ago.

Not far away, there were smoke towers in the forest. I could smell the burned sap of the trees from the camp.

A general came yesterday to ask us to act as a decoy for him. Now that we have lit up multiple villages and mass murdered their inhabitants, the orcs sure will come avenge them. The general could have at least given us some expendables.

Treating future disciples as throwaway objects ! You're a disgrace to us !

I might be a disgraced; however, I, me, possess a body.

No more replicas ? Stay dead then.

You are angry again.

Of course. Who could've guessed ?

Why ? We are helping you.

Are you ?

I cut the conversation there. I saw Paragon entering the camp. I needed to change my thoughts.

— The general congrats us. His messenger just left. Are you holding up, Phoenix ?

— Not really. Today, again, it still attempted to take over.

Who is "it" ? Do we know "it" ?

— I'm running out of ingredients to keep it at bay.

Who is "it" ? Tell me !

— Oh ! Shut the fuck up. You're interrupting a conversation that is of no concern to you. And I would rather not repeat myself.

Paragon gazed at me.

— The general has a letter for you. I peeked at it. You'll have more ingredients in the next supply run, but he is not sure if he can procure any more himself.

— Understood.

— I expect at least a thousand orcs at our doorstep tonight. I killed one of their royal children. We ain't going to win this one. I need you to operate your magic and set enough traps so the general can send us an escort. By my own power, somewhat limited, I remove any limitations placed on you.

— Understood.

After saluting Paragon, the Queen's Killer, I ran to my personal tent. I opened a cage and snatched five snakes, still living. To each of them, I hammered a nail into their body and stuffed them to the brim with saltpetre powder and a crystal scavenge from a dragon lizard. With a quill, I drew a sequence of characters on their skin.

One of these snakes received another nail. This is what happens when you guys don't stop spitting venom all over my workstation.

With my medical knife, I engraved the last character on their heads. The snakes pulsed a dozen times before leaving this world.

Left of my workbench, I stored braids of herbs, rare plants and flowers. I retrieved some and tied them around each of the dead reptiles.

When I tied the last one, Hyena, the child murderer, passed by.

— Son, lend me a hand.

I sketched five X's on a map of the camp.

— Dig a hole a quarter of your height on each of these emplacements.

— It will be done, sir.

This disciple became quite docile in four days. He doesn't have the power to hurt. But he would make a good servant.

I exited my workspace. The camp felt like an anthill. Everybody was preparing for the retreat.

I spotted a guard packing salt in a barrel.

— You. Follow me. I need that salt.

— All of it ?

— All of it.

The guard dropped some of the salt at specific locations around the camp. At the same time, I filled the spaces in between with crystal powder, herbs, animals' bones and the teeth of the orcs' mounts - wolf teeth.

In the direction of the incoming orc army, I created one more lane of crystal powder, then a circle large enough for me to fit in. With my knife, full of snake blood, I drew more characters around the circle.

The guard didn't seem to enjoy the smell. He double wrapped a cloth around his mouth and nose.

Now let's just pray it doesn't rain.

Before dusk, I filled the holes left by Hyena with the snakes' corpse. Then I linked them with what little salt and crystal powder that remained.

All that salt certainly causes damage to local plants. The grass was already fading and dying.

Herbs can't worship us.

The sun disappeared below the horizon. I missed the old times when I could enjoy it every day.

So do we.

Far into the forest, the wind rose. The wind carried with it the screams of daemons and the war drums of the orcs.

The apostles are there.

Even you, cheap God, have fallen this low as to call them apostles.

— Phoenix, we're short on time. The general's escort won't come on time. What's this preparation of yours ?

— My magnum opus. I call this piece "The birth of a God". This place will burn to ashes tonight.

Less than an hour later, orc scouts found their way to the edge of the camp. I could see their eyes in the distance. I could smell the scent of wolves. I could hear the breath of their riders.

The prisoners and the guards finished packing everything. They were ready to go.

The air changed. The main army arrived. In the distance, maybe a league from here, the orcs slammed their shields. Their royalty was there.

— Humans. Great sins have been committed. My apostles are there to avenge my child.

— Paragon, go ! I'm holding them.

I placed my hand on my plague mask. I unclipped some buckles. The strap behind my head felt to the ground.

Upon walking into my circle of crystals, I removed my mask. It's been so long, so long since the wind touched my bare skin. The mask slid off my hand to the ground.

— Shit ! said Paragon behind me. Everybody, run away !

With my knife, I cut into both palms, letting the blood seep into the crystal powder. The powder darkened.

— God of Fire, hear my request.

God of Fire ? What God would have you as a disciple?

I ignored it.

— Five of your servants lie down in this earth.

Is it a lie ?

The crystal began to glow. The orcs near the camp turned towards the light.

Do you really serve another God than us ?

I ignored that too.

— I gift you their body. I gift you this forest as food.

That God receives an offering and not us ?

The crystal powder pulsed at higher and higher frequencies. The light spread along the line I'd drawn.

The grass bent towards me.

The trees creaked.

Somewhere beneath the earth, something moved.

The orcs stopped shouting.

I smiled. It had heard me.

The daemons accompanying the orcs led the way. One of them dared to approach me.

None of them had shape. They were made of black dense fog. No smell, no sound emanated from them.

With each step, the fog pulsated. When it came within stabbing distance, it raised a hand towards my face. I grabbed his arm. The daemon started agonizing and screaming.

— Ô God of Fire. Save these poor souls. Save them from your fate. Save them from me !

The daemon dropped on the ground, shaking and convulsing as fast as the crystal powder.

Their royalty shouted something I couldn't understand.

The earth split. A crack ran through the forest floor. Fire leaked from beneath it. Then something pushed its head through.

A giant serpent. I could see its scales glow like burning coal beneath ashes. I could feel its heat on my neck at every breath of it. Behind it, the earth began to crack again.

Another serpent emerged. When it opened its mouth, I saw a nail traversing from side to side.

The third one emerged beside me. It lowered its head. Its burning scales brushed against my hand. I gently stroked them.

Stop ! Stop it ! It hurts !

I'm sorry !

Stop it !

The fourth serpent emerged. I waited for the fifth.

Instead, silence.

I waited for the voice in my head to complain.

Nothing.

For the first time in five years, the God was silent.

The earth moved again.

The orc royalty tried to calm its troops, marking itself as the first target. The fifth serpent emerged.

— My little pets, kill them all. For the God of Fire.

The third serpent launched itself at the royal orc. It took only one bite to consume the orc and its mount.

The other snakes opened their mouths. Fire swallowed the forest in front of me. Orcs caught fire where they stood. Wolves screamed as their flesh blackened. Those who tried to flee left burning footprints behind them.

I stood in the middle of it all, watching. There was nothing left for an apothecary to save.